

WOMEN MEAN business

THE 1980S

Women smashed the glass ceiling on several fronts in the 1980s, as political leaders, professionals in the workplace, and rebels on the picket line. In politics, Geraldine Ferraro became the first female vice-presidential candidate in the US, and Margaret Thatcher served as the first woman prime minister in the UK. Thatcher's steely resolve on the domestic front and the world stage helped to overturn stereotypes of the "weaker sex."

Entrepreneurs

Women began to enter sectors of the workforce previously occupied by men. In the US from 1972 to 1985, women's share of professional jobs grew from 44 to 49 percent. During that time, women gained a rising portion of college degrees, including almost one third of degrees in law, business, accounting, and information sciences. Many women took up entrepreneurial activities such as writing, selling real estate, or launching home businesses. This new entrepreneurial status was also linked to domesticity, as women such as Martha Stewart were able to monetize their skills as homemakers. Women across the

world could also earn money as sales representatives through the "home party" business model, in which they invited friends over to sample and purchase products such as Tupperware, makeup, and costume jewelry.



"[IT WAS] A PERIOD OF
ULTRA CONSERVATISM ...
YOU NEEDED BRAVE
PEOPLE TO PUSH AHEAD."

CYNDI LAUPER, SINGER, ON ARTISTS OF THE 1980s, 2010